polemics with the Soviet Union, and disputes within, events took an altogether different turn.

The issue, at the end of the day, was neither of better border claims nor of historical evidence. Nor indeed are individual incidents, however serious, the cause of the conflict. It was the politics of the period – within China, between China and India, and between China and the USSR, quite apart from the Chinese evaluation of Nehru – that precipitated a confrontation. Nehru himself realized part of that when he candidly confessed that the issue with China was not so much about territory as about domination. What he perhaps underestimated was the intensity of responses from a polity more given to use of force. Or a ‘facts on the ground’ approach that an argumentative society found truly difficult to comprehend.

The judgements of the period leading to the border conflict are an industry by themselves. But aspects that need closer scrutiny include whether forcing an earlier boundary negotiation in 1950 would have been beneficial to India. Or indeed, if the 1954 agreement on Tibet was a triumph of hope over calculation. On both sides, decisions made six decades ago still have repercussions today.

From the Indian viewpoint, political and military events of that era contributed to a larger mistrust of China. That still colours public perceptions heavily and this legacy only gets oxygen from newer controversies. As the power differential increased in the last two decades, these attitudes returned to haunt the relationship. The Chinese perhaps don’t realize how lasting the impact of the 1962 conflict has been on Indian public opinion. Indian minds do not have the same ability to move on that the Chinese have shown in respect of their own conflicts with Russia or Vietnam. The loser in the 1962 conflict was not just India but the relationship itself. As every new border face-off revives these memories, what should have receded from public focus actually remains ensconced there.

Some of the difficulties in the modern relationship also emanate from China’s handling of Tibet and its reading of India’s reaction. Evidence, even in the public domain, supports the assertion that the situation developed in a manner that was not foreseen by either nation. There is no doubt that the